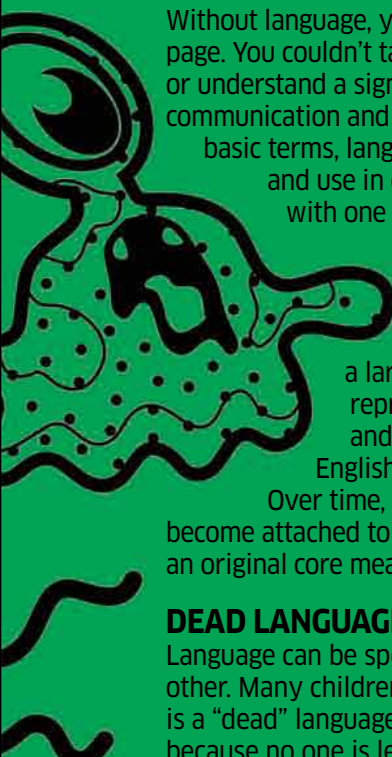


WHAT IS LANGUAGE?



Without language, you wouldn't be reading this page. You couldn't talk to friends, write a letter, or understand a sign. Language is essential to communication and therefore essential to life. In

basic terms, language is the symbols that we learn and use in order to speak and communicate with one another. The meaning of language is based on the idea that everything we might want to name, label, or express is already represented in an existing word. For example, a large gray mammal with tusks is represented in the word *elephant*, and everyone who understands the English language will know it as this.

Over time, different meanings may also become attached to the same word, but there remains an original core meaning that is universally shared.

DEAD LANGUAGES

Language can be spoken and written, or one or the other. Many children learn Latin at school, but this is a "dead" language that can only be written. This is because no one is left who can remember how to speak or pronounce the words. Other languages can only be spoken because the words have no standard written form. These languages can be expressed using the international phonetic alphabet. A language that is neither spoken nor written is sign language. This series of silent facial and hand gestures is used to communicate words to deaf people.

ANIMAL EXPRESSION

Though animals may not have a true written and spoken language like we use, it is impossible to deny that they have a form of language. It is clear that animals use noises and gestures to express themselves. People could not claim to understand what it means when a lion roars or a dog barks, but these noises may have meaning within the same species, whether it is to warn of a threat, express hunger, or simply exercise the voice box. Male whales swim the seas making a pattern of regular and predictable sounds that has been

described as singing. Scientists believe that this is to attract mates. However, such sounds have not been learned in the same way that people learn language.

LIMITS OF LANGUAGE

Is there a word for every single thing you could ever want to express? If you have tried to convey something and found it difficult to put into words, you will understand the limits of language. This is more likely to affect attempts to describe the exact way we feel in a given moment rather than obvious objects that are easy to define and explain with conventional language. As Austrian philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein (1889–1951) once said, "The limits of my language are the limits of my world." While we all learn language and recognize the meaning of each word, whether we attach the same meaning to something as someone else does is another matter. Everyone would agree what is meant by the words *tree* or *pen*, but what about *emotion* or *reason*? You may believe that you understand a word in the same way as others do, but more complex words could mean something completely different to someone else. In this way, miscommunication of language can cause conflicts between people. The study of language, called linguistics, investigates surrounding issues like these to achieve a greater understanding of how people attach meaning and communicate.

POWER OF PERSUASION

Orators are public speakers who use clever choice of language to make powerful and persuasive speeches that bring the audience around to their ways of thinking. Famous political speeches by Winston Churchill, Malcolm X, Franklin D. Roosevelt, and Abraham Lincoln have persuaded many who listened to come over to their points of view. When used in the right way, by the power of speech or the written word, language can carry so much weight that, as a result, people choose to swap political parties, adopt new belief systems, or instigate a fundamental change to their lives. So, where would we be without language? Quite simply, lost for words . . .